Addressing violence against women is another area which has received a lot of *recent attention*. Following the recent tragic incident of sexual assault in New Delhi, a committee of eminent jurists, headed by former Chief Justice of India *Justice J. S. Verma*, was constituted to review existing laws and examine levels of punishment in cases of aggravated sexual assault and it has submitted its recommendations.

An *Ordinance* has also been issued on sexual assault against women [Criminal Law (Amendment) Ordinance, 2013] based on the recommendations of the Justice Verma Committee. A Commission of Inquiry was also set up under the Chairpersonship of *Ms Justice Usha Mehra*, retired Judge of Delhi High Court to identify lapses on the part of public authorities and suggest measures to improve the safety and security of women in the capital.

New initiatives are being taken like 'one-stop crisis centres' for providing shelter, police assistance, legal, medical and counselling services with public hospitals as focal point. A scheme for providing restorative justice through financial assistance and support services to victims of rape will be implemented in the *Twelfth Plan* as per the directives of the Supreme Court of India.

Nirbhaya Fund

The *Union Budget 2013-14* announced setting up of a *Nirbhaya Fund* with a GoI contribution of Rs. 1,000 crores for *empowerment*, *safety* and *security* of women and girl children.

Welfare and Development of SCs, STs, OBCs and Other Weaker Sections

As part of the strategy to achieve inclusive development, the government is committed to the economic and social empowerment and educational upliftment of socially disadvantaged groups and marginalised sections of society.[11] Accordingly, such programmes are implemented through states, government's apex corporations and NGOs. The PPP approach is also being explored for effective delivery of services with more accountability and transparency.